They Are Lying To You About Weight Loss.

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📋 Executive Summary

A 500-calorie deficit sounds easy but is practically unreliable due to food label errors and untracked calories. A stricter formula — bodyweight × 10 calories, 1g protein per pound — is the more optimal, foolproof approach.

📑 Contents

⚠️ Why a 500-Calorie Deficit Fails in Practice 0:00

- The mainstream advice — eat at a 500-calorie deficit — is technically correct but not optimal
  - "There's a difference between what you need and what's optimal."
  - A 500-calorie deficit leaves almost no margin for error
- The FDA allows food labels to be off by **20%** in either direction
  - A food you believe is 500 calories could legally be 600 calories
  - This error can compound multiple times per day across multiple foods
- Untracked items — especially condiments and sauces — silently add hundreds of calories
  - Most people do not log sauces, dressings, or cooking oils
- Combined, label inaccuracies and untracked items can easily erase or exceed a 500-calorie deficit without the dieter realizing it

🔢 The Better Formula: Bodyweight × 10 0:21

- Recommended daily calorie target: **current bodyweight (in pounds) × 10**
  - Uses current bodyweight, not goal bodyweight
  - Creates a larger, more reliable buffer that accounts for label errors and untracked calories
- Recommended daily protein target: **1g of protein per pound of current bodyweight**
  - Again, current bodyweight — not goal bodyweight
  - This is intentionally higher than the often-cited 0.8g/lb minimum

🥩 Protein as a "Cheat Code" 0:46

- Protein has the highest thermogenic effect of any macronutrient
  - **20–30%** of the calories from protein are burned during the digestion process itself
  - Practical result: eat 100 calories of protein → body only absorbs 70–80 of those calories
- Comparison of thermogenic effect across macronutrients:

Macronutrient	Thermogenic Effect (relative)
Protein	Highest (20–30% of calories burned in digestion)
Carbohydrates	~½ of protein's effect
Fat	~⅓ of protein's effect

- The common advice that "0.8g of protein per pound is enough to build muscle" is acknowledged as true — but framed as incomplete
  - Building muscle is not the only reason to eat high protein
  - The thermogenic effect means high protein intake passively reduces net calorie absorption

    > Protein is a cheat code — your body doesn't fully absorb it because it takes so many calories just to digest it.

- The core argument: influencers promoting minimal deficits and minimal protein underestimate how easy it is for the average person to make small errors that add up to stalled weight loss